

Initial Post

by [Abdulrahman Alhashmi](#) - Monday, 27 October 2025, 10:51 PM

Design changes that steer users toward costlier choices raise core questions of honesty, consent, and fairness. The ACM study on these sneaky dark patterns highlights user interface changes that make extras the standard pick. Also, tactics can trick folks and make shady habits seem normal.

There are four key ACM rules. First, calls to "promote public good and human welfare" plus "avoid harm" mean designers must stop unfair results, such as surprise buys (Sections 1.1, 1.2). Second, "be honest and trustworthy" rules out any false display of choices (1.3). Third, "respect privacy" comes into play with designs that use personal data (1.6). Fourth, "assess systems and their impacts" calls for proof that tweaks do not take advantage of users (2.5). Leaders must set up ways to find and fix problems (3.1, 3.3).

The BCS Code supports these ideas. Principle 1 for the public interest protects privacy, safety, and rights of others. Principle 2 on competence and integrity calls for clear explanations of functions and forbids taking advantage of those with less knowledge. Principle 3 on duty to employers requires due care. Principle 4 on duty to the profession urges high ethical standards and good reputation.

Laws and social norms matter as well. Consumer protections address deceptive marketing tactics. When user data shapes the design, UK GDPR principles of lawful processing, fairness, and transparency come into play. Concealing real choices often fails these standards.

The team has clear steps to take. Drop the deceptive update. Record the risks. Offer straightforward choices that let users stay in charge. Sound the alert if needed. Could you defend this design to your users, regulators, or colleagues?

References

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